Module 4 Lecture - Research Ethics

Research Methods in Psychology

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1 Overview

1.1 Learning Objective(s)

- Define the three ethical principles of the Belmont Report and describe how each one is applied. Recognize the similarities between the Belmont Report's principles and the five APA Ethical Principles.
- Describe the procedures that are in place to protect human participants and animal subjects in research.
- Articulate some of the ways that ethical decision-making requires balancing priorities, such as research risks versus benefits, rights of individual participants versus societal gains, free participation versus coercion.
- Be able to explain the *why* of talking about ethics in psychological research; what are the philosophical reasons this topic is important to "good science"?
- Be able to understand the historical impact and ramifications of studies that led to the creation of ethical guidelines. In what way did these projects harm, deceive, or violate the trust and well-being of participants?
- Consider the principle sets presented in both the Belmont Report and APA Code of Ethics - be able to identify the numerous components and considerations in each part of these. Be able to identify what a violation of these principles would look like.

1.2 Why Do We Discuss This?

- Psychology, and other sciences, have an unfortunately _____ history - filled with _____ behavior that has harmed both willing and un-willing participants. We cannot _____ this history, as it informs us as to **why** this subject in relevant at all.
  - E.g., Eugenics movement, forced sterilization, continuation of various segregation practices, etc.
- However, just because we discuss _____ examples, does not mean that modern studies are not also threatened by ethical _____. **All** modern research must be reviewed by multiple parties tasked with _____ participants and ethics in any given study.
  - Most studies cannot even be _____ conducted before there has been a thorough review of the planned procedures.
- In our proposed research design and procedures, we can *never* _____ ethical principles. No research findings are worth completely abandoning

_____ and respectful behavior of those who participate in our studies.

2 Historical Examples

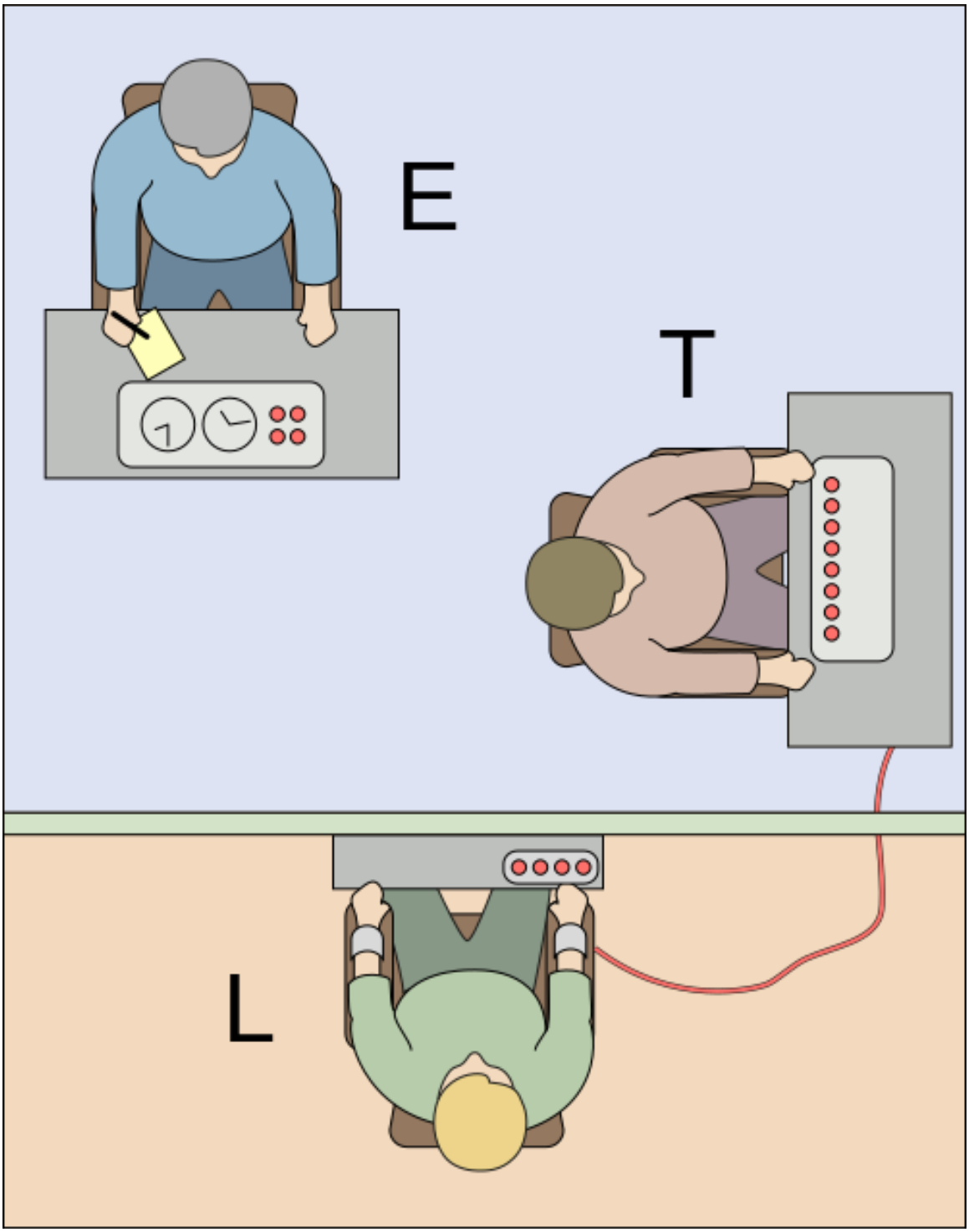
2.1 The Tuskegee Syphilis Study

- In 1932, the U.S. Public Health Service (PHS) and _____ Institute engaged in a study (the Tuskegee Syphilis Study) which, at the time, was meant to bolster public health knowledge surrounding syphilis in Black men. Instead, its historical significance is that of being the _____ for a massive research ethics overhaul in the United States, due to its numerous negligent procedures.
- The study proceeded in intentional _____, deceiving both its participants, and the broader American public. The researchers ignored well-founded _____ from whistleblowers and failed to respect the autonomy and well-being of its participants.
- Though this was a _____ study, the downstream effects and lessons learned from this study are immediately _____ to psychology and all social science and human subjects research.

- Lessons learned:
  - Participants were not treated with _____, autonomy, and dignity. They were _____, intentionally un-informed of risks and treatments, prevented from finding information that would aid them in making decision about study participation
  - Participants were intimately and immensely _____. They were allowed to suffer with the effects of the disease, despite the development of valid _____ that would have cured the disease. The study prioritized the possible results over the safety of its participants.
  - Participants were purposefully sampled as members of a vulnerable and _____ socioeconomic group. The Black men in this study were likely to be poor and have little formal education. Rather than take measures to respect and _____ each participant, this was exploited to keep participants unaware.

2.2 Milgram's Obedience Studies

- In summary, Stanley Milgram's _____ (which came in many variations; Milgram's Obedience Studies) were focused on examining how people respond to authoritative commands to inflict punishment and follow orders. These experiments were, in part, born out of questions surrounding _____ of citizens and soldiers in the Nazi regime, in Germany.
- Participants often would have some role in inflicting a perceived pain or _____ on to an actor. No actual harm was actually inflicted to the actor (a confederate), *but* participants did believe that they were inflicting the pain, usually a _____ of some degree. If they pushed back against the demand to administer the punishment (even at extreme levels), an authoritative figure would instruct them to _____ over and over.



- In this case, the flaw does not lie in harm done to the actor - the shocks weren't real, and were merely simulated. However, think about the emotional _____ in the participants - feeling "forced" by authority to perform inhumane actions.
- Though participants were _____ at the end of the study and met

the actor who assured they were fine - there are questions as to whether they were truly told that those shocks were faked. Some participants _____ for weeks.

- Lessons learned:
  - Milgram continued the studies, even after learning a staggering 65% of participants would continue the shocks to the end - usually accompanied by extreme _____ distress of the participants.
  - While the Tuskegee study showed us physical harm to the participants, this study showed us emotional _____ inflicted on the participants. Both are reasonable _____ we must consider in psychological research.
  - Was it worth it? Did we learn something so _____ that made it worth the pain those people felt…

2.3 Other Studies?

- There are no shortage of older psychological studies that follow procedures that would never be authorized today
  - e.g., Zimbardo's _____ experiment

- Just because historical studies tend to have more readily identifiable examples of ethics violations, doesn't mean _____ studies are innocent of similar errors.
  - A recent example from biology research. Remember no study is perfect, but an ethics violation is perhaps the greatest of all sins - because it _____ the very people kind enough to put their trust in us, in the first place.
- An unknown number of unethical experiments have also occurred under the direction of _____ regimes (see Unit 731)

3 Ethical Principles

3.1 Overview

- We may look to multiple sources to guide our _____ to creating ethical research. While no one source is the definitive guide, we make use these to craft a _____ at the core of our research ethics and treatment of participants.
- Much of these guidelines were created in response to _____ study and other failures in ethical research.

3.2 The Belmont Report

3.2.1 Overview

- In many ways, the Belmont Report is the _____ and most influential guiding pieces of ethical conduct for *any type of human subjects research in the United States.*
- Though it is very comprehensive and _____, it can be summarized by focusing on 3 core principles: Respect for _____, Beneficence, and Justice. In your future work in the research proposal and article critique, I want you to be very cognizant of these virtues in your writing and reading.

3.2.2 Respect for Persons

- Respect for Persons Consists of two applications: autonomy and _____ for limited autonomy
- **All people are autonomous.** In practice, this means that we allow each person to _____ their own participation or non-participation in a study. They are entitled to sufficient knowledge to weigh benefits and risks. A person cannot be _____, deceived, or offered excessive incentive to obtain consent.
- **Some people are limited in autonomy due to outside factors.** There are _____ groups which are, in one way or another, limited in their ability to give informed consent.
  - Examples: those with intellectual/developmental disability, minors, _____, those under a medical guardianship or power-of-attorney.
  - In these cases, researchers must act with _____ precautions to protect vulnerable individuals.
  - Procedures may involve obtain consent of a guardian and _____ of the person under the guardianship.

3.2.3 Beneficence

- The beneficence principle is critically concerned with *minimization* of harm and acting in the best _____ of participants and the broader population represented by the sample of the study.

- Now, studies may, by virtue of the research questions, require some degree of harm. However, it is absolutely _____ that researchers do their best to anticipate, avoid, and _____ harm wherever it may occur.
  - This often requires that researchers regularly assess the state of participants and ensure they are not _____ harmed by study procedures. Studies may need to be changed (with approval) or outright stopped if risk of harm grows _____ than expected.
- Within this principle, is the necessity of ensuring _____ through completely anonymous studies and/or **confidential studies**. Harm can come to individuals in information is leaked or shared. Institutions will have strict data _____ to protect the information gathered about participants in studies.

3.2.4 Justice

- The Justice principle highlights the importance of considering the larger _____ of the study and the potential negative effect on the study participants to achieve such a result.
- We should avoid using a sample that is _____ or useful by virtue of their position (e.g., those considered "vulnerable" as stated before) to benefit the broader population.
- Put another way, we should be concerned with _____ that there is equity between the groups under study, and the larger group that benefits from said work.

3.3 The APA Ethical Principles

3.3.1 Overview

- The APA Guidelines supplement and apply the Belmont report principles specifically to psychological science and practice. In some ways, it expands and adds further detail to " _____ " the principals.
- 5 core principals
  - Beneficence and _____
  - Fidelity and responsibility

  - _____
  - Justice
  - Respect for people's rights and dignity
- These guidelines provide further definition and _____ on a variety of topics, named the Ethical Standards for Research

3.3.2 Institutional Review Boards (IRBs)

- The IRB is the central _____ body overseeing ethics in research at any given institution. They are responsible for carefully inspecting and evaluating the planned methods of any given study, but especially _____ subjects studies.
  - The IRB often requests *extensive* documentation on planned studies and procedures well in _____ of when they happen. It is not uncommon to have a nearly completed methods section and introduction sections before a study is even approved
  - E.g., Neuropsychological Study at Trinity
- They are a _____ step in approving research, prior to conducting a study. Without IRB approval, a study *cannot* proceed.

3.3.3 Informed Consent

- Under many studies, a researcher must provide each _____ a form that indicates the general goals of the study, likely benefits and risks, as well all procedures for a person to _____ participation.
- Regulation do allow for informed consent to be waived under circumstances, such as when data was already gathered (e.g., census data, electronic health record data from routine care) or when a person could "reasonably expect" to be seen by the general _____. However, this waiver must be _____ asked for and explained.
- IRBs carefully _____ whether a study must employ informed consent forms based on the risk to individuals and data anonymity.
  - As with any component of a study, and IRB can request changes or outright force a certain course of actions

3.3.4 Deception

- Intentional deception and _____ as part of a study's methodology are fairly common and can be done ethically, *with caveats*.
  - Examples: Milgram's shocks, confederates (actors), etc.
  - Lie by leaving information out is called omission where _____ giving false information is called commission Deception should only be used to the point that it is absolutely necessary to the goals of the study.
- First, the deception must be _____ as necessary to the goals and validity of the study. It must be done intentionally to protect specific goals and threats to the study.
  - For example, a participant who knows a study is about implicit bias towards and out-group may act _____ their normal self in order to appear "better"
- Second, this deception must be thoroughly _____ and explained to the IRB, with appropriate debrief planned for after completion of the study.
- Deception isn't a universally loved _____, but many recognize it as a necessary part of studies to isolate psychological effects from bias in participants.

3.3.5 Debriefing

- Debriefing sessions occur with participant _____ their participation in the study, in which the methods used are explained, and any deception is revealed.
- Researchers may share results with people, so they are aware of findings, and can possibly benefit from the research. Functionally, we debrief for the same reason we share _____ procedures in published work: to increase trust in the process and science.

3.3.6 Research Misconduct

- This term is mostly related to the _____ practices of **Data fabrication and/or falsification**.
- Fabrication: When data is _____ to support certain conclusions

- Falsification: When data is _____ pruned, filtered, or treated to bias it towards favorable conclusions. This is also relevant when procedures are use that bias participants in their reactions.
- Both of these acts of research misconduct may have wide and longstanding effects on professional _____ of researchers, as well as public effects

3.3.7 Openness and Transparency

- As a general rule, one should _____ share the procedures, analyses, and data used to complete research (see Merton's openness norm) - unless to share these would jeopardize the security and privacy of subjects.
  - Not all data _____ is allowed by certain organizations - sometimes this decision is somewhat out of the researcher's hands
- Pre-registered hypotheses, data sharing agreements, and code-sharing can all be _____ practices to allow research practices to be better inspected by interested parties. It can also be useful in catching small errors, leading to corrections or retractions when necessary.

3.3.8 Plagiarism

- Plagiarism is said to be passing another person's work or words off as your own. It is especially easy to do in research _____, when we rapidly state claims and evidence from prior literature.
- Plagiarism can be both un-intentional/accidental or fully _____ - however, the implications of both types are largely the same, and the _____ tend to be equally severe.
- It is also possible to self-plagiarism. This may seem paradoxical, but the reuse of the same sentences as part of a _____ work implies that the sentence originated in the new work, when it did not. When submitting graded or publishable work, it is expected that the piece is _____ and unique to other work.
- The two strategies for avoiding plagiarism are to use good _____ and proper APA 7th citations and references. We covered this earlier in our workshop introducing APA style.

3.3.9 Animal Research

This will be less of a focus for this class, but you will need to have some general notions of the nuance in this area. Generally, animals should be used sparingly, and should be treated with the utmost respect for their contributions to studies.

- Lab animals (those kept explicitly for research purposes) have specific ethic _____ governing their care, habitat, and treatment.
- Lab animals are governed by Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee (IACUC), a sort of IRB-for-animals
- 3 Rs
  - Replacement : try to find _____ to using animals, wherever possible
  - Refinement : minimize harm to animals with better, less intrusive lab procedures
  - Reduction : Try to use as _____ animals as possible
- Public opinion on animals can be very mixed, and certain advocacy groups seek to outright _____ the use of animals in lab studies. However, many also recognize that use of animals is tightly governed (just like with humans) and critical to some areas of research especially _____ for humans (like early stage clinical trials).

3.4 Making Decisions Ethically

- Just like with the 4 validities we discussed, there is no one, clear way to _____ all the ethical considerations a researcher must make.
- The Belmont Report and APA Ethical Code are good starting points, and universities should have Responsible Conduct of Research (RCR) office, as well as IRB(s). Most organizations _____ the completion of ethics certifications programs through the CITI program, prior to being part of formal research teams.
- Ethical decision-making will combine with what we've learned about crafting and evaluating claims so that we can _____ balance the many components of a good research project. Your research proposal and will need to _____ ethical concerns around research, in addition to the already established validities and claim types.

4 Conclusion

4.1 Recap

- In this lecture, we covered the brief history of ethics and ethics problems to consider in psychological research
- We also discussed how to recognize ethical problems and how to use the Belmont Report and APA guidelines to design ethical research

Key Terms

A

anonymous studies Those in which identifying information about participants is never collected 10
APA Guidelines A new set of guidelines designed for psychological research, born out of the Belmont Report principles 10
autonomy A persons's ability to make decisions for themself 9

B

Belmont Report The original and most influential guiding piece of ethical conduct in US research, born out of the Tuskegee Study 9
beneficence A principle of the Belmont Report, regarding acting in the best interest of each participant 9

C

commission Deception by providing outright false information 12
corrections When a journal article is changed after being published, for the purpose of correcting an error in the original articles 13

D

Debriefing The process by which a participant has the study explained to them, and deception is revealed, after the conclusion of the study 12
deception When a participant is 'lied to' for the purpose of the study 12

E

Ethical Standards for Research An expansion of the APA guidelines to provide practical explanations and guidelines to follow 11
ethics A study of how to behave in a way to respect and protect participants in research 2

F

Fabrication The creation of fake data to support conclusions; a form of research misconduct 12
Falsification The modification of existing data to support conclusions; a form of research misconduct 13

I

informed consent A process by which a person makes an informed decision on whether to participate in research 11
Institutional Animal Care and Use Committee (IACUC) An IRB-like body for governing animal research 14
IRB The central governing body for research ethics on human subjects at an institution 11

J

Justice A principle of the Belmont Report; focused on equally studying all of those who results will be relevant to 10

L

limited autonomy When a person's autonomy is somehow limited by emotional, physical, or cognitive factors 9

M

Milgram's Obedience Studies A series of studies by Stanley Milgram unethically studying obedience and responses to authority 5

O

omission Deception by leaving information out 12

P

Plagiarism The unethical conduct of copying another's work and passing it off as your own without attribution 13

R

Reduction A process in animal research to use as few animals as possible 14
Refinement A process in animal research for trying to improve procedures to have minimal negative impact on animals 14
Replacement A process in animal research for trying to find viable alternatives prior to using animals 14
research misconduct Describes unacceptable acts of fabrication and falsification in research 13

Respect for Persons A principle of the Belmont Report, consisting of autonomy and respect for limited autonomy 9
retractions When a journal article is removed from publication due to severe errors 13

S

self-plagiarism When one plagiarizes one's own work by not recognizing the first occurrence of work 13

T

Tuskegee Syphilis Study An unethical study involving non-treatment of debilitating syphilis in Southern Black men 3

The instructor-provided glossary may not include all terms worth memorizing, make sure you consider using the vocabulary list in you book and your own judgment to make sure you have all relevant terms